NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣10

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣9

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3♣
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A K 6
♥ A 10 3
♦ A 8 2
♣ 10 9 7 4

♠ J 10 5 4
♥ 8 4
♦ J 10 9 6
♣ J 8 2



♠ Q 9 2
♥ K Q J 9 7 5
♦ K Q 3
♣ 6

♠ 8 7 3
♥ 6 2
♦ 7 5 4
♣ A K Q 5 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♥	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥K

Partner's jump to 3NT is a lebensohl method.

He is describing a hand with which he would have bid 3NT if there had been no overcall. But he is warning you that he **DOES NOT HAVE** a ♥ stopper!

Since you **DO** have a ♥ stopper you decide to pass and play 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥K.

You hold up your ♥A until the third round.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 7

You need two more winners. Barring a 4-0 ♣ split your two extra winners will be the ♣5 and ♣3.

So after winning the ♥A, you play a ♣ to dummy's ♣Q and breathe a sigh of relief when both defenders follow suit.

UhOh. Surely you didn't play your ♣4 to dummy's ♣Q???

If you did then just look at the situation now. If the ♣J doesn't fall on the next trick the suit will be blocked. Now go back in time and play the ♣10 to dummy's ♣Q.

That's better. Now under the ♣ A K you can unblock the ♣ 9 7, which will leave you with the ♣4 to slip under dummy's ♣5.

Watch those spot cards. You may have to unblock them to stay in the hand you want to be in.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 6 ♥ Q 9 8 5 3 2 ♦ Q 10 ♣ A J 6 3	
♠ K Q J 9 5 3 ♥ K J 7 ♦ 6 2 ♣ 8 4	N W E S	♠ A 4 2 ♥ A 6 ♦ A J 8 4 3 ♣ Q 7 2
	♠ 10 8 7 ♥ 10 4 ♦ K 9 7 5 ♣ K 10 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
4♠			
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♣10

You decide to use a transfer so the lead will be into whatever holding partner has in the minor suits. You bid 2♥ and partner bids 2♠.

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You are nowhere near strong enough to be thinking of slam so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by West.

East plays 4♠. South leads the ♣10. North wins the ♣A. They continue ♣s and you ruff the third one in dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

Those losers are based on dummy's hand, not yours. You can figure them either way but it is usually easier to determine losers based on the long-trump hand. It's important to remember it in this Deal because the zero losers in ♥s assumes you will ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Pull one round of trumps with dummy's ♠K. Both defenders follow suit. Play the ♥A, then ♥6 to dummy's ♥K. On this trick South follows with the ♥10.

The Plan is still the same, you will ruff the ♥ in your hand, but you better be sure to ruff with your ♠A. Aha! Your precaution pays off when South shows out of ♥s, but of course he cannot over-ruff your ♠A.

A very good Bridge maxim is this:When you are ruffing, ruff with as high a trump as you can afford.

Here, with only 2 trumps left out, you can afford the ♠A.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ K 10 9 8 6 5
♥ Q
♦ 7 4 2
♣ K Q 6

♠ 7 3 2
♥ J 9 7 4 3
♦ A 10 6
♣ 9 2



♠ A
♥ 10 8 5 2
♦ 9 8 5 3
♣ A 10 8 7

♠ Q J 4
♥ A K 6
♦ K Q J
♣ J 5 4 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♣9

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer so you bid 2♠. Partner now bids 4♠ and you pass.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♣9. East takes the ♣A, then returns the ♣7 on which West plays the ♣2.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 3

Careful! Although it looks like only 3 losers you are in real danger of a ♣ ruff. It is almost certain that West has led a doubleton ♣ so if East can get the lead with either ♠A or ♦A they will get the ruff.

Fortunately your ♦s are solid and you do not need the ♥Q as a winner.

So before playing any trumps play ♥ A K, discarding dummy's ♣K. That's a lot of winners you are wasting but you can afford it.

Only then can you afford to play a ♠. East can win the ♠A, but if he plays a ♣ dummy will be able to over-ruff West.

After you pull trumps you can drive out the ♦A and claim the contract.

As you see, trying even one round of trumps would have been fatal.

You had to get rid of dummy's singleton ♥ first - the fact that it was a winner should not affect your making the correct play.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ K J 7 2 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ Q J 4 ♣ A 7	
♠ A 9 6 ♥ 9 8 4 2 ♦ A K 7 3 ♣ K J	N W E S	♠ 5 3 ♥ 7 6 ♦ 10 5 ♣ 9 8 6 5 4 3 2
	♠ Q 10 8 4 ♥ A K 5 ♦ 9 8 6 2 ♣ Q 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
1NT	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♣			
All Pass			

3♣ by West
Lead: ♥Q

Many people play Jacoby Transfer convention. Not all of them play that an initial response of 2♠ asks partner to bid 3♣. You use that here and reply 3♣. Everybody passes.

What a terrible dummy! This shows why this method is a good addition to Jacoby Transfers.

West plays 3♣. North leads the ♥Q. South takes the ♥ A K, then switches to the ♠Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = ? :: Total = 3 + ?

Instead of trying to estimate how many ♣ losers you may have, just tell yourself that you can only afford to lose one! Then you base your plan on that requirement.

You might as well win the ♠A. You need to play the trumps from dummy and the easiest way to get there is to play ♦ A K, then ruff a ♦. Now play a ♣ from dummy and play what from your hand?

You may think it is a guess whether to play the ♣K or ♣J, but there is no guessing involved here. You must play the ♣J because South cannot possibly hold the ♣A. Just go back and look at the bidding again. The South hand failed to open the bidding in first seat. And since then you have seen the ♥ A K and the ♠Q come out of the hand. That's 9 points and the ♣A would bring that total to 13. Since he passed it follows that he doesn't have the ♣A. Of course he might or might not have the ♣Q, you just have to hope for that card.

It's easy to forget the bidding once you have started playing a hand.

But good players don't forget, they use every bit of information they can get to help them make their contracts. That's why they make more contracts.